destruction of life and property which have plagued mankind since time immemorial, we may be tempted to agree with the pessimistic philosophers who consider life worthless and deny the possibility of permanent progress, of a betterment of mankind, and who profess instead that it is the fate of every human civilization to turn blindly against itself as soon as it has reached a certain peak, and to destroy itself without sense or purpose.

May exact science be cited as an evidence of such a far-reaching view? The answer must be “No,” if for no other reason, because science is not qualified to decide the question. From the scientific point of view, one might just as well, and perhaps with even more justification, endorse the opposite opinion. It would require merely an extension of the range of observation, a thinking not in terms of centuries but of many millennia. Or is there anybody who would seriously deny that during the past one hundred thousand years *homo sapiens* has made progress and has improved himself? Why should this progress not continue further—if not in a straight line, then at least in waves?

Of course, such considerations, such a long-range view, are no help to the individual. They cannot bring him succor in his hour of need or cure his pain. The individual has no alternative but to fight bravely in the battle of life, and to bow in silent surrender to the will of a higher power which rules over him. For no man is born with a legal claim to happiness, success and prosperity in life. We must therefore accept every favorable decision of Providence, each single hour of happiness, as an unearned gift, one that imposes an obligation. The only thing that we may claim for our own with absolute assurance, the greatest good that no power in the world can take from us, and one that can give us more permanent happiness than anything else, is integrity of soul, which manifests itself in a conscientious performance of one’s duty. And he whom good fortune has permitted to co-operate in the erection of the edifice of exact science, will find his satisfaction and inner happiness, with our great poet Goethe, in the knowledge that he has explored the explorable and quietly venerates the inexplorable.